

The Second Interview

She had failed this interview once before. Now she was back — and everything had changed.

CEFR Level A2

Book 1 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: London. A marketing agency called Bright & Co. Two years apart.

Genre: Career Drama / Personal Growth

Characters

- Nadia — 29. Marketing coordinator. Ambitious but self-doubting.
- Claire — 45. Head of Creative at Bright & Co. Direct, perceptive, fair.
- Joel — 31. Nadia's colleague at her current job. Supportive friend.
- Marcus — 52. The interviewer from two years ago. Now retired.

Nadia was reading her emails on a Tuesday morning when she saw it.

The subject line said: Bright & Co — Senior Creative Coordinator — Interview Invitation.

She read it three times. Then she put down her coffee cup very carefully.

Two years ago, she had applied for a junior position at Bright & Co. She had got to the final interview. And then she had failed.

Not failed exactly — they had chosen someone else. But it had felt like failure for a long time.

Two years ago, Nadia had prepared for weeks. She had researched the company, practised her answers, bought a new jacket.

The interviewer — a man called Marcus — had asked her one question she had not expected.

'What has been your biggest professional mistake, and what did you learn from it?'

Nadia had frozen. She had talked about something small and unimportant. She had known, even as she was speaking, that it was the wrong answer.

The rejection email came four days later.

Nadia told Joel about the email in the kitchen at work.

'Bright & Co?' Joel said. 'Isn't that the place that—' He stopped.

'Yes,' Nadia said. 'That place.'

'Are you going to apply?' 'I already did. Two years ago. This is a different role — more senior.'

Joel poured his coffee. 'So are you going to accept the interview?' he asked.

Nadia looked at the email again on her phone. 'I think so,' she said. 'But I need to think about the question.'

'What question?' 'The one I got wrong last time.'

That evening, Nadia sat at her kitchen table with a notebook.

She wrote at the top of the page: What has been my biggest professional mistake?

She thought for a long time. Then she wrote:

'Two years ago, I was managing a social media campaign for a small client. I noticed that the data was showing poor results after the first week. But I didn't say anything — I was afraid of looking incompetent. I waited three weeks. By then, the client had lost a significant amount of money.'

She read it back. It was uncomfortable. But it was true. Over the next two weeks, Nadia prepared differently from before.

She didn't just research Bright & Co — she studied their recent campaigns, read interviews with Claire Foster, the head of creative, and contacted two people who had worked there.

She wrote down ten questions she might be asked. Under each one, she wrote a real answer — not a polished, perfect answer, but an honest one.

Joel read through her notes one evening. 'These are good,' he said. 'They sound like you.'

'Last time I sounded like someone trying to be impressive,' Nadia said. 'That's what I got wrong.'

On the morning of the interview, Nadia woke up at six. She made coffee. She looked out at the grey London morning. She read her notes once — not to memorise them, just to remind herself.

Then she put the notes away.

She thought: I know what I want to say. Either they will like it, or they won't. But I am going to say the truth this time.

The Second Interview



Nadia receives a second interview invitation from Bright & Co.

She got dressed. She put on the same jacket she had worn two years ago. It still fitted. Some things don't change. Some things do.

The Bright & Co offices were on the fourth floor of a glass building near Waterloo station.

Nadia remembered them from two years ago — the exposed brick walls, the plants everywhere, the smell of coffee and paper.

The receptionist smiled at her. 'Nadia? Claire is ready for you. Follow me, please.'

Nadia followed her down a corridor. The walls were covered in framed campaign posters.

She recognised one of them — a campaign she had studied last week.

'I know this one,' she said quietly, almost to herself.

Claire Foster was shorter than Nadia had imagined.

She had grey-streaked hair and reading glasses pushed up on her head.

She stood up and shook Nadia's hand firmly. 'Nadia. Sit down. Can I get you water?'

'Please.' Nadia sat. She noticed that Claire's desk had no computer on it — just notebooks and a coffee cup.

'I read your application,' Claire said. 'You've been at Meridian for two years. Why do you want to leave?'

It was a direct question. Nadia had expected it.

'Because I've learned everything I can learn there,' she said. 'And I think I'm ready for something harder.'

They talked for twenty minutes about Nadia's experience, her ideas for the role, and two campaigns she had worked on.

Then Claire leaned back in her chair.

'One more question,' she said. 'What's been your biggest professional mistake — and what did you actually learn from it?'

Nadia felt a small jolt of recognition. The same question. Almost exactly.

She took a breath. She told Claire about the campaign, the data, the silence, and the client who had lost money.

She did not rush. She did not apologise. She just told the truth.

'After that campaign,' Nadia said, 'I made a rule for myself. If I see a problem, I say something within twenty-four hours. Every time. Even if it makes me look bad.'

Claire was quiet for a moment. Then she said: 'Has that been hard to keep?'

'Yes,' Nadia said. 'Once I told a very senior client that his brief was unclear. He wasn't happy. But the campaign was better.'

Claire wrote something in her notebook.

'Good answer,' she said. Not warmly — just factually. As if she were noting a correct answer in an exam.

The interview lasted fifty minutes. At the end, Claire walked Nadia to the lift.

'We're seeing three more people this week,' Claire said. 'We'll let you know by Friday.'

'Thank you for seeing me,' Nadia said.

Claire paused. 'Can I ask — did you apply here before? I looked at the name on your application and thought I recognised it.'

Nadia felt her face go slightly warm. 'Yes. Two years ago. Junior coordinator.'

Claire nodded. 'I thought so. You're considerably stronger now.' She pressed the button for the lift.

'Friday,' she said.

Nadia called Joel from the street outside.

The Second Interview



Nadia answers Claire's hardest question with honesty.

'How did it go?' 'I don't know. I think it went well. But I don't know.' 'Did you answer the question?' 'Yes.' 'The real answer?' 'Yes.'

'Then it went well,' Joel said.

'She might not give me the job,' Nadia said.

'That's different,' Joel said. 'Going well and getting the job are two different things. You can go well and still not get it. But you went well.'

Nadia stood on the pavement and thought about this. He was right.

Wednesday. Thursday. Nadia worked. She answered emails. She went to two client meetings. She did not check her personal inbox compulsively — she checked it twice a day, morning and evening.

This was a new habit. She had learned it the hard way two years ago, when she had checked her phone every twenty minutes for a week.

On Thursday evening, Joel sent her a message: 'Any news?' 'Friday,' she replied. 'Tomorrow.'

Joel sent back: a thumbs up emoji. Nothing else. That was what she needed.

On Friday, the email came at eleven forty-five.

Nadia was in a meeting. She felt her phone vibrate in her pocket. She left it.

When the meeting ended at twelve fifteen, she went to her desk. She opened her laptop.

The email was from Claire Foster.

Nadia read the first line. Then the second. Then she put her hands flat on the desk.

She read it again from the beginning.

The email said:

Dear Nadia, Thank you for coming to interview on Wednesday. We were impressed by your experience and, in particular, by the clarity and honesty of your answers.

We would like to offer you the position of Senior Creative Coordinator, starting on the 3rd of next month.

Please confirm by end of business today.

Claire Foster, Head of Creative, Bright & Co

Nadia read it a third time. Then she called Joel.

Joel answered on the second ring. 'Well?' he said.

Nadia took a breath. 'I got it.'

Joel was quiet for three seconds. Then: 'I knew it. I said you went well.' 'You said going well and getting the job were different things.' 'I know what I said. I also knew you got it. Both things can be true.'

Nadia laughed. It was the first real laugh she had had that week.

'I'm buying you lunch,' she said. 'Not necessary,' Joel said. 'But yes, please.'

Nadia's last day at Meridian was on a Friday. Her colleagues got her a card and a plant.

She packed her desk into one box — it didn't take long, which made her a little sad.

She stayed late to finish a handover document for the person taking her job.

Before she left, she went to Joel's desk.

'Ready?' he said. 'Ready,' she said. They walked out together.

Outside, it was raining lightly. Nadia didn't have an umbrella.

'It's fine,' she said. 'I don't mind the rain.'

The Second Interview



Nadia moves forward with confidence after hearing yes.

On her first day at Bright & Co, Nadia arrived at eight fifty.

Claire was already there. She showed Nadia her desk — near a window, with a view of the street below.

'You'll spend the first week meeting the team and reading through current projects,' Claire said. 'Don't try to fix anything yet. Just observe.'

'Just observe,' Nadia repeated.

'Yes. There will be plenty of time to have ideas. First — understand where you are.'

Nadia sat at her new desk. She opened her notebook. She wrote the date at the top of the first page.

On her second day, Nadia was walking down the corridor when she stopped.

She was looking at the same campaign poster she had noticed during her interview.

A colleague named Priya stopped next to her. 'That one's from three years ago,' Priya said. 'Before my time. But it's one of the best things we've done.'

'I studied it,' Nadia said. 'Before my interview.' Priya raised her eyebrows. 'Seriously?'

'I wanted to understand what you value here,' Nadia said.

Priya smiled. 'That's a good sign,' she said.

Two years later, Nadia was sitting on the other side of the table.

She was interviewing a young woman named Sofia for a coordinator role.

Nadia had prepared her questions carefully. Near the end, she asked:

'What's been your biggest professional mistake — and what did you actually learn from it?'

She watched Sofia carefully. She knew what a frozen, polished non-answer looked like.

She also knew what a real one looked like.

Sofia took a breath. She started talking. Nadia leaned forward slightly.

It sounded like the truth.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. subject line	konu satırı
2. applied for	başvurdu
3. junior position	alt düzey pozisyon
4. final interview	son mülakat
5. failure	başarısızlık
6. prepared	hazırlandı
7. researched	araştırdı
8. practised	pratik yaptı
9. rejection email	ret e-postası
10. frozen	donakaldı
11. senior	kıdemli, üst düzey
12. accept	kabul etmek
13. poured	döktü
14. think about	... hakkında düşünmek
15. got wrong	yanlış yaptı
16. managing	yönetiyordu
17. campaign	kampanya
18. data	veri
19. incompetent	yetersiz
20. significant	önemli miktarda
21. campaigns	kampanyalar
22. polished	cıvalı, kusursuz
23. impressive	etkileyici
24. honest	dürüst
25. studied	inceledi
26. memorise	ezberlemek
27. remind herself	kendine hatırlatmak
28. either... or	ya... ya da
29. got dressed	giyindi
30. fitted	uyuyordu
31. exposed brick	açık tuğla
32. receptionist	resepsiyonist
33. corridor	koridor
34. framed	çerçevesi
35. recognised	tanıdı
36. grey-streaked	gri telli
37. firmly	sıkıca
38. application	başvuru

39. direct question	doğrudan soru
40. ready for	... için hazır
41. leaned back	yaslandı
42. jolt of recognition	tanıma hissi
43. apologise	özür dilemek
44. rush	acele etmek
45. took a breath	nefes aldı
46. rule for myself	kendime kural
47. look bad	kötü görünmek
48. brief	brifing, görev tanımı
49. factually	olgusal olarak
50. noting	not alıyor
51. lasted	sürdü
52. considerably	oldukça, önemli ölçüde
53. stronger	daha güçlü
54. pressed	bastı
55. paused	duraksadı
56. called	aradı
57. pavement	kaldırım
58. two different things	iki farklı şey
59. still	yine de
60. right	haklı
61. compulsively	obsesif şekilde
62. inbox	gelen kutusu
63. habit	alışkanlık
64. the hard way	zor yoldan
65. thumbs up	beğeni, onay
66. vibrate	titreşmek
67. left it	bıraktı (cevaplamadı)
68. flat on the desk	masaya yassıca koydu
69. from the beginning	başından
70. meeting ended	toplantı bitti
71. impressed	etkilendik
72. in particular	özellikle
73. clarity	netlik
74. confirm	onaylamak
75. end of business	iş günü sonu
76. second ring	ikinci çalış

77. both things can be true	her ikisi de doğru olabilir
78. necessary	gerekli
79. laughed	güldü
80. colleagues	meslektaşlar
81. packed her desk	masasını topladı
82. handover document	devir teslim belgesi
83. lightly	hafifçe
84. umbrella	şemsiye
85. observe	gözlemlemek
86. current projects	mevcut projeler
87. plenty of time	bol zaman
88. repeated	tekrarladı
89. understand where you	are
90. raised her eyebrows	kaşlarını kaldırdı
91. seriously	ciddiye alarak
92. value	değer vermek
93. good sign	iyi işaret
94. before my time	benden önce
95. interviewing	mülakat yapıyor
96. leaned forward	öne eğildi
97. slightly	biraz
98. polished non-answer	cilalı sahte yanıt
99. it sounded like	... gibi geldi

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

Word

Meaning

1. applied for
- A. netlik
2. rejection
- B. başvurdu
3. clarity
- C. red
4. observe
- D. kampanya
5. campaign
- E. gözlemlemek
6. handover
- F. devir teslim
7. compulsively
- G. obsesif şekilde
8. impressed
- H. etkilendik

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

prepared — honest — frozen — senior — confirm — mistake

1. Two years ago, Nadia _____ at the key question in her interview.
2. She spent two weeks getting _____ for the second interview.
3. This time she applied for a _____ position — not a junior one.
4. Her answers were _____ — not polished or perfect, but true.
5. The email asked her to _____ by end of business.

6. The biggest _____ was not saying anything when she saw the problem.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Nadia is applying to Bright & Co for the first time. ____
2. Two years ago, she failed because she was rude. ____
3. Joel is a colleague at her current job. ____
4. Claire is the interviewer from two years ago. ____
5. Nadia gets the job offer by phone. ____
6. At the end of the story, Nadia is interviewing someone else. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What happened at Nadia's interview two years ago?
8. What was Nadia's real professional mistake?
9. How did Nadia prepare differently this time?
10. What rule did Nadia make for herself after the campaign mistake?
11. What does Claire say about Nadia at the end of the interview?
12. What does Joel mean by "going well and getting the job are two different things"?
13. How does Nadia wait for the result — differently from two years ago?
14. What does Claire tell Nadia on her first day?
15. Why does Nadia ask the same question in her own interview at the end?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-C 3-A 4-E 5-D 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. frozen 2. prepared 3. senior 4. honest 5. confirm 6. mistake

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. T 4. F 5. F 6. T

7. She froze at the question about her biggest mistake and gave a vague, unhelpful answer.

8. She saw poor data on a client campaign but stayed silent for three weeks out of fear.

9. She studied real campaigns, contacted former employees, and wrote honest answers.

10. If she sees a problem, she says something within twenty-four hours.

11. She says Nadia is considerably stronger than two years ago.

12. You can perform well in an interview and still not be chosen — they are separate outcomes.

13. She checks her inbox twice a day, not every twenty minutes.

14. Spend the first week observing and understanding, not trying to fix things.

15. Because it is the question that reveals honesty and self-awareness — she learned that from her own experience.